by changing lifestyles and eating habits that require more water per person. The production of biofuels has also risen sharply, with significant impact on water demand. Between 260 and 1,060 gallons (1,000– 4,000 liters) of water are needed to make about ¼ gallon (1 liter) of biofuel.

In the last century, half of Earth's wetlands have disappeared to make way for farmland or development, or because groundwater has been removed from aquifers faster than it has been replaced. A reduction in wetlands means plants and animals dependent on them are also gone. Nearly half of all drinking water comes from aquifers. About 240 cubic miles (1,000 cubic km) is taken every year. This water is used for irrigation, industry, and domestic purposes. In high-income countries, around 40 percent of water withdrawals are used for agriculture, but in low-income countries, this can rise to over 90 percent. However, most aquifers replenish much more slowly than they can be emptied, so water yields reduce with use. If the water table falls, some lakes and rivers dry up. About half the total length of China's rivers has been lost since 1990. In North America, the Great Lakes are shrinking, Lake Winnipeg is under threat, and the massive Ogallala aquifer is being depleted. Even Brazil, the most water-rich nation on Earth, has water supply problems. As the situation worsens, it becomes a growing source of conflict.